

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

VIJAY RAINA, 55

Now living in Delhi;
original resident of Habba Kadal, Srinagar
Fled the Valley on March 8, 1990

You don't forget the events that force you to run away from your own home, no matter how much time passes," says Vijay Raina, sitting in his apartment in Delhi's Mayur Vihar area where he lives with his wife and two sons. Now employed with a private firm, Raina says he has never gone back since he and his parents fled the Valley 32 years ago. "The mere thought of returning fills me with fear. What would I return to, anyway? I left nothing back there," he says. Delhi, on the other hand, has given him safety, stability and is what he considers home today.

Raina's father had been in Doordarshan and the family lived in Habba Kadal in Srinagar. A night after his father's colleague was gunned down on March 7, 1990, people came to their home asking for his father. "I pretended he was in Jammu," Raina recounts. "They were not strangers or Afghans. They were our neighbours—people we grew up with, played cricket with, went to school with."

EVEN TODAY, *GAANTH GOBHI*, A VEGETABLE KASHMIRI PANDITS ARE PARTICULARLY FOND OF, REMINDS RAINA OF BLOOD AND DEATH

It was at this point the family decided to leave. Raina was 24 at the time. They made their way to the refugee camp near Geeta Bhawan in Jammu, where they stayed for nearly a month. In Delhi, Raina's father rejoined Doordarshan. The hardest part for Raina was dealing with the mental and emotional scars. Even today, *gaanth gobhi*, a turnip-like vegetable Kashmiri Pandits are particularly fond of, reminds Raina of blood and death. He had been at the local grocer's to buy a kilo of the same when a blast ripped through the area. It was the 42nd year of India's Independence and Raina remembers first going mad with fear and then fainting. "There was darkness and blood. When I looked down at my own leg, I saw a cylinder lodged in it," he says. He then takes out a faded clipping of an Urdu newspaper that has his photograph printed in it. "I was hospitalised," he recalls. The physical trauma has eased since, but the emotional scars seem permanent. "Being a victim, a refugee, becomes a part of who you are. You cannot ever fully dissociate from it."

–Sonali Acharjee

In his 1991 book, *My Frozen Turbulence in Kashmir*, Jagmohan claims he was thwarting a plan by militants to cause mayhem on Republic Day. But there were also allegations that the governor had told the Pandits to leave the Valley so that he could launch a crackdown on militants uninhibited by the fear that they would wreak revenge on the community. Senior officials who were present at that time, though, say they had heard of no such plan. Moreover, the way Pandits fled, leaving home and belongings behind, indicated they were doing it out of fear. The administration was clearly unprepared to handle the waves of targeted strikes. Neither the security forces nor the army guarding the borders were called in to provide Pandits protection. There was intelligence failure too, whether on Pakistan's motives or on the way militant groups had joined forces to gain the upper hand. Meanwhile, in March 1990, Pakistan began a military exercise called the Zarb-e-Momin, designed to prepare their troops to invade India, and take Kashmir. Seeing the dangerous dimensions things were acquiring, India warned Pakistan against contemplating any such misadventure.

Jagmohan's misadventures, however, continued. On May 21, 1990, Mirwaiz Maulvi Farooq, the Valley's popular spiritual mentor, was assassinated, with the Hizbul reportedly claiming responsibility. It created a wave of resentment in the ordinary Kashmiri Muslim against the militants, who then spread the rumour that the Shiv Sena was behind the killing. The spontaneous outpouring of grief saw a huge crowd join the maulvi's funeral procession. No one knows why it happened, but panicked CRPF jawans opened fire against the procession, killing 52 people. The Kashmiri Muslim was alienated even further and the Kashmiri Pandit again bore the brunt of terror attacks. "Moderate Kashmiri Muslims too were targeted by extremist groups to frighten them into compliance," reveals a senior official. "And while there are enough reports of Muslims sheltering persecuted Pandits, business rivalry and the competition for land also saw many turning a blind eye. Those were truly dark days that brought out the worst in all of us." The orgy of violence would continue for over a year, by which time an estimated 75,000 Pan-